SpeechGeek

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In just a matter of a few weeks we'll move into a new year. For those of us in the world of education, it traditionally marks the halfway point of the school year. Though everyone else has their minds on starting from scratch, we're in the thick of things. For many forensic coaches, now is the time of year when you address what's working with your team and what exactly isn't.

A little introspection never hurt anyone.

Challenge your students to pick up the pace as we move down the stretch toward state tournaments, qualifiers, and (they'll be here before you know it) Nationals. The first semester doesn't really matter any more. Come January, you'll be rested and ready to go.

Okay, maybe the sense of renewal the new year brings isn't really all that different between forensicators and the real world.

That could very well be a first.

Best of luck as your season continues! It is my that 2007 is filled with fun adventure for both you and your program.

Corey Alderdice
Publisher

In This Issue:
Season Four: Spring 2007

Prose Interpretation
Thrift
by Daschle Stephens.....04

Dramatic Interpretation
Topaz
by Paul Davis.....09

Poetry Interpretation
Progam Builder: Past the Profundity
by Stephanie Patterson.....11

Duo Interpretation (Male/Female)
Schrodinger's Kiss
by Bonnie Minkey.....15

Duo Interpretation (Male/Female)
Saving Face
by Trevor Anders.....19

Thrift

by Daschle Stephens

Humiliation has always played an integral part in self-discovery, and I suppose my life is no different. In my high school Intro to Drama class – we had to go around the room and introduce ourselves by telling everyone what animal we were most like. The other guys were panthers. They were grizzlies, lions, eagles, and boa constrictors – they were beasts of power, strength, and virility. Me? I was a squirrel. So while every other turbo-testosterone charged teen male was on the prowl – I was left open to a barrage of hi-larious innuendos about my "nuts". It never got old.

Now in my own defense, the squirrel thing isn't as asinine as it may sound. Growing up, money was tight around my house. We were by no means starving, but we had a healthy appreciation for what we had. Much like squirrels, my younger brother, Kevin, and I were always on the lookout to gather resources for home. If we were good during the week, my mom would take the two of us out to McDonald's for a family dinner on Friday. After finishing our Happy Meals, my brother and I would make sure to grab extra salt, pepper, and packets of "fancy ketchup" to take home for future dinners. At age 8 this ritual is charming and endearing. At age 28 you're called cheap by merciless friends and coworkers – to which I always respond, "Back off – my meatloaf is now delicious *and* fancy."

Sundays were always spent diving through the paper for the coupons and sale sections. Eventually my brother and I would create games to make the task of bargain hunting for mom a little more enjoyable. Sometimes we would compare products at different stores to see who had the best deals, and to make the stakes more interesting: the one with the lower price gave the other an Indian Sunburn or during the holidays – a delightful Texas Tittie Twister. Scissors askew - we flew like starving junkyard dogs through the sections. Kevin had an eye for office supplies and clothing sales but I always delivered a weekly whooping when it came to frozen foods and produce. Working two jobs to make ends meet, my mom appreciated the help though she never really saw the need to spend money on the frivolous things that kids find to be the most important. Case in point – neither Kevin nor I ever had a real lunchbox. And by real, I do mean the plastic box with a cartoon or action hero on the front. Mom figured that the plastic bags that we brought home our groceries in worked just fine. This never really bothered me, but it always seemed to irritate the other kids at school who felt the need to show off: A). The lunchboxes that their parents bought them and B). The unforgiving physics the thin bag had on my chips when met with someone's balled up fist before walking to the bathroom.

It was at this point that I usually emptied the contents of a packet of "fancy ketchup" into one of their open cans of Dr. Pepper. The projectile vomiting that followed would ensure the safety of my chips in the future. But this didn't stop my mom from trying to stencil Optimus Prime on my grocery bag the next day out of guilt.

*

If being thrifty made me the weird kid – it has also made me an awkward adult. As I move grudgingly through the end of my 20's, I still have the charm of Beaver Cleaver in the throes of puberty. My hair cowlicks in angles not found in advanced geometry classes, my clothes are so far from being name brand that the tags are blank, I can never find anything witty to say and I laugh like Pee-Wee Herman. Ladies…control yourselves. One good thing to come of my money conscious upbringing was the ability to crunch numbers freakishly well resulting in a passion for mathematics and yet another way to drive away the opposite sex. These days I work as a computer programmer at a faceless corporation. Sure, there are the same predator archetypes in the work place as there were in high school – but for every squirrel there are a dozen lions and panthers ready to bust my bushy behind into submission. There's a reason why you don't see many squirrels

Past the Profundity

by Stephanie Patterson

RESPONSE

You stood glittering
gold under artificial lamps robed
in a white coat of Marlboro smoke
so thick I mistook you for the love
child of Zsa-Zsa Gabor and Sean "P-Diddy" Combs
In a moment too quick to grab solid
ground you heaved and curled
hurled violence into space vomited
forth into amplified airwaves
Poetry that isn't political
is a waste of my time
Apparently for you
volume speed and anger are ingredients
for a Molotov Cocktail of persuasion
a recipe you must have stolen from my family
the only place where passing
warm buttered bitterness and hot carved contempt
was always successful You are
a short sighted visionary turning poet on poet
Chewing and consuming each other's
words till we're left standing over the corpses of works
turning to creativity cannibalism Slapping
faces of new poets who clutch journals so closely
to their chests you'd think them paper pacemakers
the only thing keeping bleeding hearts beating Shadows
on the wall at readings leaving bars and coffee shops
without ever having exhaled life
into the mic Fearing their performance wasn't
fierce enough Their words aren't strong enough
That their poetry doesn't fit the mold but poetry
like goldfish can't grow
in bowls

The most important poets never perform

The most important poets are the
18 year-old emo poets so soaked
With angst they bleed black eyeliner

Or the 44 year old beat poets
fleeced in long sleeves and bongos beating
bass strings like jazz

Or the 23 year old street poets with fingers
so prettily pressed on the city's pulse their
lyrics become prescriptions

Or the 67 year old man who doesn't know
onomatopoeia from alliteration but pens
tender tiny love poems and hides them

in cabinets and drawers for his aging wife.
Her mind gracefully peeled by time Stripped
away of memories of their life together But he
still pens love poems about their life together
hoping that though poorly written she'll know
if only for a moment
that when he kisses the ground she walks on
it makes the earth sigh
and the resulting breeze
forces trees
to bow on
knotted knees
when she
passes by

But when you say
Poetry that isn't political
Is a waste of my time
words that were once sweet and nourishing
like milk turn to curds and sour in my mouth
and chunks thunk down to my stomach
Making both my brain and bowels burst
forth with a fury better left for Greek deities.

Because separating the political from the personal
is like setting up the joke
and leaving out the _____

And I can't help but wonder perhaps
if street lights were accompanied by open
mics illuminating open minds filling the streets not with
"Poets"
but people writing poetry Emerging from
shadowed alleys pleading and begging with
paper words to give them momentary immortality
To make them gods among mortals To help
them know that having faith in people should
come as easily as having faith in God Then
perhaps a poem can't overthrow the world

But it can change a mind.

And sometimes – that's enough.

So when you bellow, dear poet
Poetry that isn't political
Is a waste of my time
please know
that you are wasting mine.

HUNGRY

His posture seemed to sink a bit. He stood
beneath the boxes. Face to face, he stared
at tigers, athletes, spoonfuls bearing flakes
that used to come to him. He never cared
about the store or the shopping. He had spent

his life at tables, waiting, he would falsh
his spoon in jest at his wife. Now he's left
alone. He feels like time has played a trick
on him, he's lost in aisles in search of hands
to hold his. Boxes taunt him. Labels scream out: New
and Improved! More Fiber! Low Carb!
Cartoon grins twist like ghouls. If only he
could open up the boxes. Taste a few
to find the right one, perhaps, then, the pain
of feeling like a dog in the rain would cease.
In truth, it won't. Now teenage kids walk past
and laugh aloud at the crazy old man lost
among the breakfast goods for hours on end.

FOR MY PARENTS

You brace yourself for the family meal.
Familiarity breeds strategy. You prepare
not for the worst: but for the usual.
You've flown home to Dallas for business
leaving cool brick walls for something
more concrete. Your mother picks you up
to come to her birthday dinner, which she
cooked herself. At dinner, the conversation
ping pongs across typical topics
politics, religion, and the downfall of society.
Being the lone liberal of the family –
you bear the burden of all three, but are
spared by your Master's degree and good credit.
You clear the dishes as the grandparents
steer the conversation toward another birthday topic,
death,
proclaiming that they've purchased burial plots,
not in North Texas with your mother
but in South Dakota with her brother
and other distant relatives that,
to you, are frozen in frequently told family folklore.
You wipe dishes clean as your mother wipes
her eyes before she cuts a piece of her birthday cake.
Your grandparents explain:
they aren't being cruel. Just realistic.
You could never see the difference between the two.
As a teen, trips to bargain chain stores
were punishments for wanting to be hip.
You'd fight with your mom
claiming she loves the dog more than you.
(You can't blame her.
The dog never left home, though
you never pooped on the floor. That
you can remember, at least.)

Family vacations were circus acts.
You and your brother were the main act:
two bears in tutus clawing and wailing in the back seat.
Driving the travel trailer off the Grand Canyon
seemed to be a merciful finale. It wasn't until
college did you realize how good you had it.

You look back at thousands of utilitarian
tokens of affection: oil changes, clothes, 'fun money'
taken for granted with the arrogance of youth. Your
mother's jungle gym body of
your youth is now a Faberge Egg of her age.
Your father's hair is now more salt than pepper.
the product of his working one job (to feed the family)
and working to support the family as a strong,
silent, responsible foundation
so you could have so easily what he struggled
to earn.

When dinner is over you sit with your mother.
She tells you about your father about health
problems you've previously been sheltered from.
You are mystified to learn such a large heart is deceptive
in its delicacy. Your mother has never lived
on her own. She doesn't know about bills,
money market funds, or how to turn on the computer.
Your father always balanced the checkbook
while the rest of you hid in fear of "overdraft" so
when your mother says
I hope I go first
your heart becomes blue glitter.
It bursts, blowing billions of bits that stick to skin
and get crushed in the carpet. You are winded by the
brute force of her honesty. You picture a funeral
and burst into tears. You cry easily.
You get this from your mother.
You picture one without the other.
An old boot on the highway
lost without its "sole-mate".
You are cheesy.
(You get this from your father)
You snowball into an avalanche of tears,
snot and slobber. The idea of the family careening
off the edge of the Grand canyon seems a merciful
finale. You realize that one day
they will both be gone. You will be an orphan,
no matter how old you are.

On the flight back from Dallas
you think back to one Christmas.
Attic steps sigh while your mother screams
and slaps your father.
It seems your father farted in your
mother's face as they descended from the
attic. Your mother scolds your father:
You're going to wake the kids
Your father laughs hard, making himself fart,
again,
on the eve of Christ's birth.
You look out the window of the airplane.
You never remember feeling so high.